tricolour at every roundabout and street corner – and we hadn't even reached the final yet.

I remember standing on the balcony of my hotel room and watching the celebrations till late at night. I also remember telling Anjali that it was an unbelievable sight and she had to see it to believe it. It emphasized to me yet again how much the World Cup meant to our cricket fans. However, it was only to get bigger with India meeting Pakistan in the semi-final.

Neighbours

Soon after we landed in Mohali and were on our way back to the hotel, I asked my team-mates if any of them had the Amit Kumar song 'Bade Achhe Lagte Hain' on their iPods. Finally, it was Mane Kaka, our masseur, who said to me that he had it with him. Mane Kaka has always been an exceptionally affectionate person, constantly doing the best for us without expecting anything in return. I subsequently requested DJ, our computer analyst, to download the song onto my iPod as soon as possible, and it was the only song I listened to for the next seven days.

The match in Mohali on 30 March was always likely to be the most intense of the competition and in fact it turned out to be one of the most pressured games of my career. Playing Pakistan in a World Cup semi-final on Indian soil – it just couldn't get any bigger. As the two teams practised side by side we could feel the tension. Both teams badly wanted to win this one. Up till then India had an impeccable record against Pakistan in World Cups, and we wanted to keep that record intact.

We got off to a dramatic start in what turned out to be a rollercoaster of a game, thanks to Virender Sehwag taking on Umar Gul. He was the form fast bowler for Pakistan in the tournament and Viru's assault set us rolling. Viru raced off the blocks and hit Gul for four fours in his second over. Fortunately the Pakistanis dropped me a few times, the chance to midwicket being a relatively simple one, and my innings of 85 proved vital as we lost a few quick wickets in the middle overs, with Wahab Riaz taking five in the match. Riaz bowled Yuvi first ball and the momentum shifted like a pendulum many times in the course of the match. So much so that I had my heart in my mouth on a number of occasions during this nailbiter. Suresh Raina played well for his 36 not